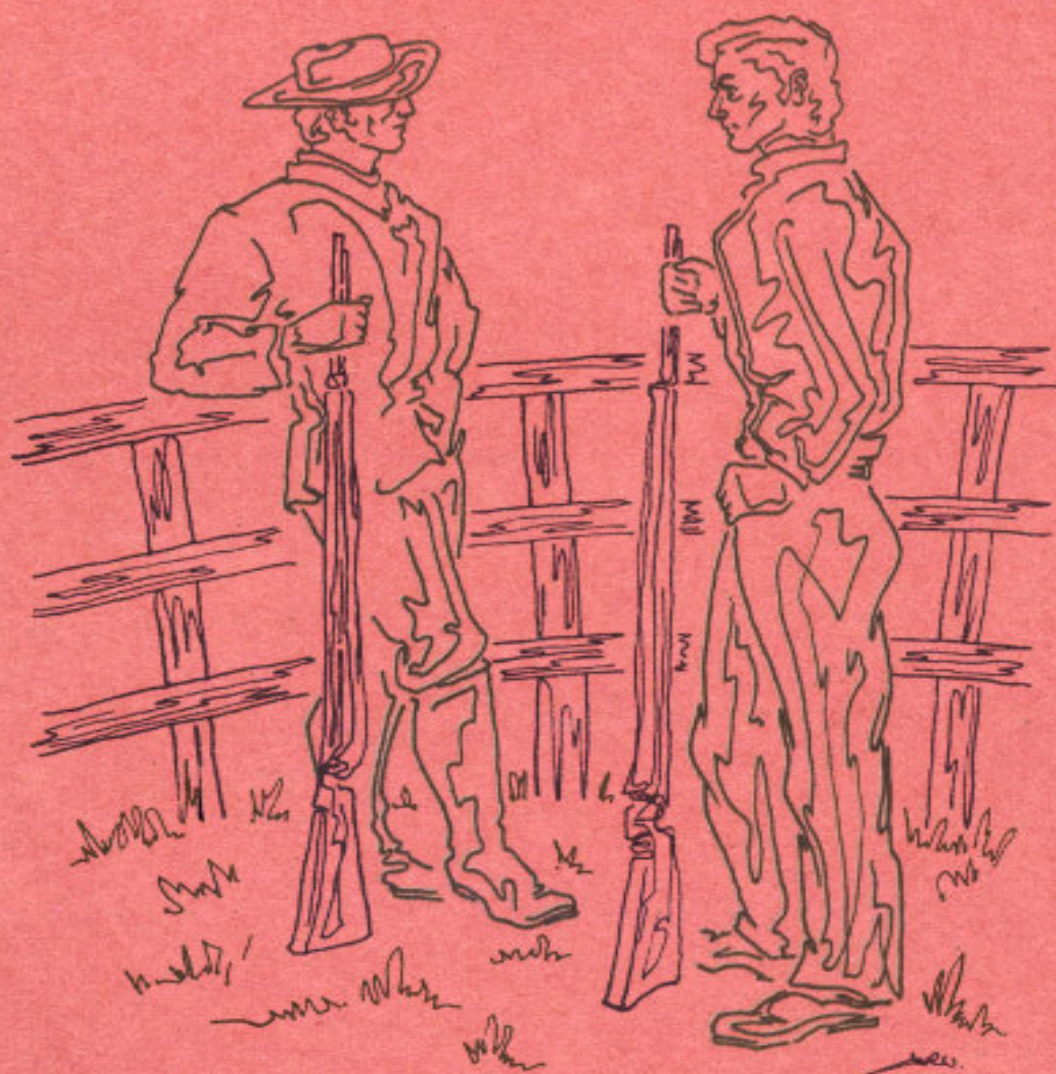
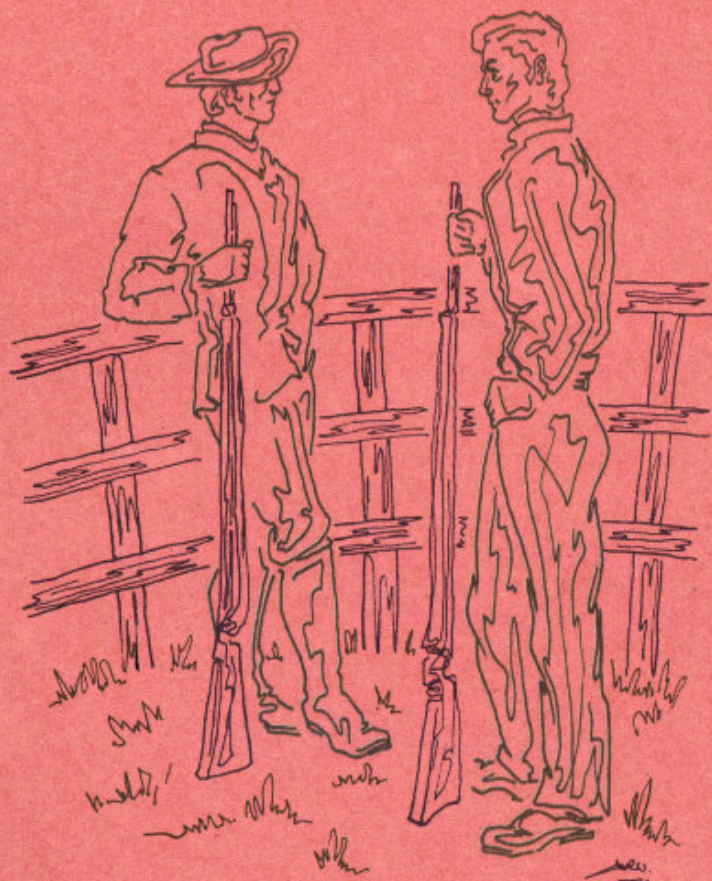


THE IRISH WAR



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THE IRISH WAR

Prepared by the staff of the
Public Library of Fort Wayne and Allen County
1953

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FOREWORD

Irishmen who had recently immigrated to the United States were the chief source of labor for the construction of the Wabash-Erie Canal. Much strife among the canal workers stemmed from regional antagonisms in their homeland, and personal violence resulted on more than one occasion; the so-called “Irish War” was one such episode.

David Burr, one of the canal commissioners, made the following report on the incident. It was printed as an Indiana state document and is often quoted as authority for statements made about the “Irish War.” It is now out-of-print. Because the Boards and staff of the Public Library of Fort Wayne and Allen County consider it valuable source material, it is reprinted here, together with the accompanying letter of transmittal. Grammar, spelling, and punctuation have been changed to conform to current practice.

1

STATE OF INDIANA HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

December 31, 1835
Read and referred to the Committee on Claims

Executive Department
Indianapolis, Indiana
December 30, 1835

The Honorable C. B. Smith
Speaker of the House of Representatives

Sir:

I lay before the House of Representatives the particulars, in writing, of the late riots upon the line of the Wabash Canal, which details were furnished at my request by one of the canal commissioners. With this history, I also submit the claims of the commandants, Captains Murray and Tipton, who, at the heads of their companies, repaired to the scene of disorder in support of the civil authority and liberally advanced money and provisions for the service. It will be seen that the laborers along the line in the adjoining counties had assembled in preparation for battle, making Wabash County the theater of their riotous conduct; consequently, that county would seem to be chargeable with the expense of the arrests and the prosecutions which followed. But as the occurrence was one of an unusual kind, growing 2 out of, and threatening the progress of, the work in which the state is engaged, it is believed the treasury of that county is not justly chargeable with the expense. It is recommended that the commissioners appointed to assess damages to private property or one of the fund commissioners be authorized to examine the different claims and to direct their payment, so far as would be right, out of the canal fund.

Respectfully,
Noah Noble

3
Indianapolis, Indiana
December 30, 1835

The Honorable Noah Noble
Governor of Indiana

Dear Sir:

In conformity with your request in relation to the disturbance amongst the Irish laborers on the Canal, it is proper to state that many persons of the two parties into which they are unfortunately divided, "Corkonians and Fardowns," had been engaged in those bloody affrays at Williamsport in Maryland and at the "high rocks on the Potomac" within the last two years. They had come since September in 1834 to the Wabash and Erie Canal with, as it is said, many of their leaders. Of course, they had brought their

animosities with them. And from that time up to the twelfth of July last, when the general riot took place, they manifested their ill will to each other by merciless beatings on such persons of each party as chanced to fall in the power of the other.

On a considerable portion of the line there was no justice of the peace in these newly organized counties. As these frays were confined to the Irish alone, and to the least worthy amongst them, not much effort was made, and perhaps could not have been made, by the civil authority to suppress them. This exasperating course of hostilities increased until it became unsafe for the Irish to travel from one part of the line to the other without great precautions for their safety. Events proceeded to such an extent that they were mutually afraid that each party would have its cabins burnt and the inmates slain in the night.



Because of mutual fears and for safety the laborers had so hired out to the contractors that they had about equally divided the line between the parties; the Corkmen worked on the upper part, and the Fardowns on the lower part of the line. The beatings of such persons who were caught away from their friends increased to such a degree, and the parties became so exasperated, that about the first of July a determination became general that one or the other should leave the line. The worthless amongst them, by carrying threats of burnings and murders which were to be committed by falling on the defenseless in the night, so excited their fears that they left their houses and cabins and hid out in the woods without light or fire to betray their hiding places. The whole line, armed in military array, worked generally in the daytime until some idle report would get in circulation that one party was marching to fight the other. Then they would leave their work and hasten with great rapidity to the supposed point of danger. 5

From the fourth to the tenth of July, these alarms were constant and were aggravated by the threats and outrages of the worthless. The length of line occupied by these belligerent parties was nearly fifty miles. On the tenth of July the parties hastily collected; or rather, they left their work and commenced a march towards the center of the line for a general battle.



Two days before this, I reached that part of the line, heard there was to be a turnout, but supposed it only rumor without foundation. I saw several persons and tried to convince them that no such thing would take place. On the tenth, however, one of the engineers reported that all the

workmen on the lower end of the line were armed and were marching to the reputed battlefield. I met them about half a mile from my residence. They were in very orderly array and well armed; not a noisy or a drunken man was amongst them. They were forced, so they considered, to fight in order to protect themselves and to avoid being slain and to keep their property from being burned at night. They stated that the civil authority did not, or could not, protect them; that their families could not stay in their shanties but had to sleep in the woods; and that they had no resource left but a battle. They further stated that the weaker party should leave the line; that they wished to work and remain peaceable but could not; and that they would rather fight fairly in open day than be subject to these depredations at night. With the assurance that order would be restored and that I would negotiate a suspension of hostilities with the other party, I prevailed on them to wait until I could see their belligerent friends.

I then went to the reputed battlefield with three or four persons whom I supposed had influence with them. I found them fully prepared, well disposed in a strong military position, and exceedingly exasperated; and I had some difficulty in saving those who went with me from being killed. They expressed the same fears as the others but, after some persuasion, consented to appoint persons to agree on terms of peace with the Fardowns. They also agreed to suspend hostile operations until the result of the meetings between the persons deputed to negotiate the peace could be known.

In the meantime, the citizens at Huntington had become exceedingly 8 alarmed at seeing this hostile array; three or four hundred armed men on each side had the avowed intention of meeting in battle; the civil authority was completely powerless. Fearing their persons and property would not be safe, they sent to Fort Wayne for aid of the militia. A company immediately was collected and in a few hours was sent to their relief. Meanwhile, the citizens of Huntington had collected and organized a company also.

By this time, the citizens of Lagro became alarmed; they sent to Huntington for the troops to come and protect them and aid the civil authority. As soon as I learned that the militia had turned out from sixty to one hundred in

number, I thought the force altogether too small to do any good against seven or eight hundred armed men. Therefore, I sent to Logansport and requested assistance, which was promptly rendered. The militia at Lagro, at my request, marched to Miamisport and met the two volunteer companies from Logansport; and all marched back to Lagro.

Two magistrates, an associate judge, the sheriffs of Huntington and Wabash counties, and the militia arrested and committed eight of the ringleaders. There was no safe jail on the canal line. Therefore, in order to remove the cause of contention, these men were sent under a strong guard to Indianapolis for safekeeping. Here they were confined until they were liberated by a writ of habeas corpus because of some informality in the proceedings.

There were more than six hundred armed Irishmen, and I am satisfied that no course other than the one pursued would have been sufficient to restore order. The commissioning of justices of the peace and the organizing of militia companies at Wabash, Lagro, and Huntington have restored, and I trust will preserve, order.



The commissioners, Messrs. Johnson and Lewis, were at Fort Wayne at the time; and I had not the benefit of their advice. As soon as order was restored, the canal board took more decided steps in their regulations. They now require each contractor to dismiss any laborer who may engage in a broil and to give his name to the engineers so that he may not be employed on the line. 10

The militia turned out on the first moment's warning; many of the men just happened to be in town and marched off without any preparation whatever. They had of necessity to be supplied with money and provisions for their subsistence. These were furnished by many of the contractors and people on the line. Amongst those incurring the greatest expense was Captain Elias Murray, of Huntington; he took command of the temporary garrison at Lagro, assisted the civil authority in making the arrests, and, with his company, marched the prisoners to Indianapolis. He was engaged some three weeks in the service.

Colonel John Spencer, of Fort Wayne, who headed the militia from that city, and General John Tipton, who was active in forwarding the volunteer companies from Logansport, paid a large portion of the expenses. One of the prisoners who had been sent to Indianapolis was arrested on his return to the canal line, was convicted, and was sent to the penitentiary. On his way there he escaped from Mr. Johnson, the sheriff, who offered a reward of \$100.00 and paid it for his apprehension. Wabash County was also at great expense in sending the prisoners to Indianapolis. Other persons on the line were also at much expense in money and provisions. 11

This expenditure was absolutely necessary for the preservation of order; it was the means of saving many human lives by preventing at least seven hundred armed and highly exasperated men from fighting a battle. It was also the means of preventing a total suspension of canal work which might have ensued for the greater part of the season since July. It would, therefore, be very desirable indeed if some provision could be made by law to remunerate those persons who have been at so great expense.

Some of the bills for the money expended are in the possession of the Board of Canal Commissioners. But, as they have only a small part, the

appointment of some person to hear and examine claims and to authorize payment is respectfully suggested. The selection of a member of the Board of Fund Commissioners, who had no part in these transactions and would therefore constitute an impartial tribunal, is also suggested. As the matter in question grew out of the operations on the Canal, and as the commissioners have the funds in their possession, such an appointment would seem to be suitable.

With great respect,
David Burr

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